Free Tier Guide: running the final project on AWS or GCP without a surprise bill

This guide covers both tracks of the final project, **AWS** and **GCP**. It shows how to sign up, which free allowances matter for this project, how to build the project so it fits inside them, and how to avoid the usual billing traps.

> **Terms change.** Every number below was checked on the official pages on **2026-11-06**. Before you rely on a number, open the link next to it and check it again. If this guide and the official page disagree, the official page wins.

---

1. Which track should I choose?

Your situation	Choose	Why
You have an AWS account created **on or after 15 July 2025** with credits left	**AWS (own account)**	New accounts get credits and a 6-month Free plan (see §4.1)
You have an older AWS account that is still inside its 12-month free tier	**AWS (own account)**	Classic free tier (t2.micro/t3.micro etc.); check what's left in *Billing → Free Tier*
You never had a paid Google Cloud / Maps / Firebase account and never used the GCP trial	**GCP (own account)**	$300 Free Trial credit for 90 days, plus Always Free (see §4.2)
Both free offers are already used up, or you can't add a card	**AWS Academy Learner Lab** (AWS track)	Course-provided sandbox with its own credit; no card needed
You already used everything above	Talk to the instructor **early**	See §7

You may switch tracks only before you start building. Mixing clouds in one project is allowed only where the assignment says so (e.g. GitHub Actions + one cloud).

---

2. Sign-up, step by step

2.0 Before you start (both clouds)

- **Use your own card, in your own name.** Never use a parent's, friend's or company card. If something goes wrong, they get the bill.
- Kazakhstani bank cards (including virtual and debit cards) usually work, but sign-up places a **small temporary verification hold** that is released later. Make sure the card is enabled for online and foreign payments and has a small balance. If the card is declined, try a virtual card from your bank app.
- Use your **personal** email, not a shared one. Turn on **MFA** right away.
- Create **budgets and alerts first, before any resource**. This is the most important step in this guide.

2.1 AWS (own account)

1. Go to https://aws.amazon.com/free/ → **Create a free account**. Choose the **Free plan** if asked. On the Free plan you are not charged; the account closes when the plan ends unless you upgrade (§4.1).
2. Sign in as **root**, then **Security credentials** → **Assign MFA device** (authenticator app).
3. **Billing and Cost Management** → **Budgets** → **Create budget**:
   - a **zero-spend budget** (alerts at any charge), and
   - a **monthly cost budget** set to your variant's budget (or a small amount like $5), with alerts at 50 / 80 / 100%.
4. **Billing preferences** → **turn on Free Tier usage alerts** (email when you approach a free-tier limit).
5. Create an **IAM admin user/role for daily work** with MFA, and stop using root.
6. Choose one region and stay in it, e.g. `eu-central-1` **(Frankfurt)** for latency from Almaty, or the region your variant says. Make sure every service you need exists there.
7. Bookmark **Cost Explorer** and **Billing** → **Free Tier**. You'll check them every day you work (§6).

2.2 GCP (own account)

1. Go to https://cloud.google.com/free → **Get started for free**. Sign in with your personal Google account, enter your address and card. Google uses the card to verify your identity and may also ask you to verify your bank account.
2. You get a **Free Trial billing account with $300 credit for 90 days**. Billing is **not** switched to paid automatically (§4.2).
3. Create a project for the course, e.g. `<resource_prefix>-final`.
4. **Billing** → **Budgets & alerts** → **Create budget** for the project. Use your variant budget (or a small amount), with alert thresholds at 50 / 90 / 100%.
5. Turn on **2-Step Verification** on the Google account. In IAM, grant others only what they need (no Owner for automation; use a service account).
6. Choose a region:
   - For **Always Free** compute and storage you must use `us-central1`, `us-east1` **or** `us-west1` (§4.2).
   - For trial-credit resources you may use `europe-west3` (Frankfurt) or another region. Keep everything in one region.

7. Bookmark **Billing** → **Reports** and the **Free Trial status / credit balance** page.

2.3 AWS Academy Learner Lab

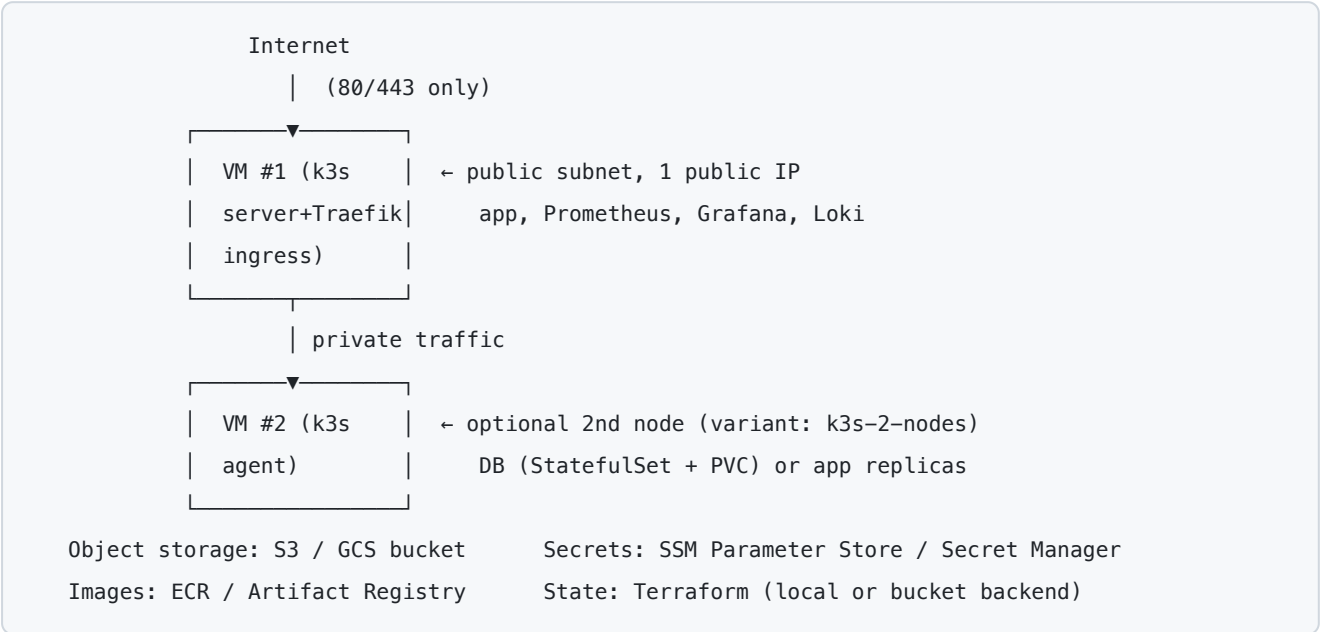
- No sign-up and no card: you get access from the course in AWS Academy.
- Things to know **per the Learner Lab Readme** (read it in the lab):
  - The lab has a **limited credit**. The remaining budget is shown in the lab; when it's gone, the lab account is disabled.
  - A **session lasts a few hours** (shown as a timer). When it ends, running EC2 instances are **stopped** and restarted the next time you start the lab. Your data is kept.
  - Only certain regions are allowed (usually `us-east-1` and `us-west-2`) and only a subset of services.
  - You **cannot create IAM users or roles**. Use the provided `LabRole` / `LabInstanceProfile`.
  - CLI credentials are **temporary**: copy them from *AWS Details* each session.
- Because instances stop between sessions, **design for restart**: services must start on boot (systemd / k3s), and nothing important may live only in memory.

---

3. A free-tier-friendly architecture for this project

The project needs Kubernetes, a self-hosted database, object storage, secrets, monitoring, logging, IaC and CI/CD. Here is how to fit that into free allowances and credits.

Recommended baseline (both clouds):



- **Kubernetes = k3s on 1–2 small VMs.** A managed control plane is not free: EKS costs **$0.10 per cluster per hour** (EKS pricing). GKE has a free tier for one cluster's management fee (§4.2), but nodes still cost money. Use managed Kubernetes only if your variant says `managed-k8s-if-credits` and you watch the credits closely.
- **VM size:** k3s + PostgreSQL/MySQL + Prometheus/Grafana/Loki needs more than 1 GB of RAM.

    - The always-free e2-micro (GCP) and t3.micro/t4g.micro (AWS) have 1 GB, which is enough only for a single light piece (e.g. the DB node).
    - Plan **~2 GB or more** for the main node: t3.small / t4g.small on AWS, e2-small / e2-medium on GCP. Keep in mind this uses credits.
- **Database: self-hosted in the cluster** (StatefulSet + PVC) **or on VM #2**, never a managed DB (the assignment forbids it, and it eats credits).
- **No NAT gateway.** Give the one public VM a public IP and keep VM #2 private, with egress only when needed. Or put both in a public subnet, lock them down with security groups / firewall rules, and explain the trade-off in your report.
- **Load balancer only for the demo.** Use the k3s ingress (Traefik) on the public VM day to day. If your design needs a cloud LB, create it with Terraform for the demo and destroy it afterwards.
- **Monitoring and logging inside the cluster** (Prometheus + Grafana + Loki/Alloy): no cloud bill. If your variant is `cloud-logging-fluentbit`, keep log volume small (§5).
- **Secrets:**
    - On AWS, use **SSM Parameter Store standard parameters**: no additional charge (Systems Manager pricing). Secrets Manager costs $0.40 per secret per month (pricing), but it's fine for 1–3 secrets on credits.
    - On GCP, Secret Manager's free tier is 6 active secret versions and 10,000 access operations per month.
- **Terraform state:** a local file plus a careful `.gitignore`, or a bucket backend. **Never commit state:** it can contain secrets.

---

4. Free allowances that matter for this project

> Checked 2026-11-06. **Verify on the official page — terms change.**

4.1 AWS

Accounts created on or after 15 July 2025 (AWS Free Tier, Free Tier FAQs):

Item	What you get
Credits	**$100 at sign-up** plus **up to $100 more** for completing activities in the *Explore AWS* widget, so **up to $200**
Free plan length	**Up to 6 months** or until credits run out, whichever comes first
When the Free plan ends	AWS **suspends** the account, keeps your data for **90 days**, then **permanently deletes** it unless you upgrade to a Paid plan
Charges	None on the Free plan unless you upgrade. Usage above always-free limits is paid from your credits
Always free	"30+ services" with monthly always-free limits (see each service's page)
EC2 free-tier eligible types	**t3.micro, t3.small, t4g.micro, t4g.small, c7i-flex.large, m7i-flex.large** (EC2 free tier usage)

Older accounts (before 15 July 2025): the classic 12-month free tier; eligible EC2 types are **t2.micro and t3.micro** (same EC2 docs page). Check what's left in *Billing → Free Tier*.

Per-service limits relevant here:

Service	Free allowance / price to know	Source
EC2	Eligible types above; check usage in *Billing → Free Tier*	EC2 docs
T4g trial	Until **31 Dec 2026**: **750 free hours/month of t4g.small** for all customers (surplus CPU credits still charged)	EC2 docs
Public IPv4	**$0.005 per IP per hour**, in use or idle, since 1 Feb 2024. Free tier includes **750 hours/month** of in-use public IPv4 for EC2 free-tier customers	VPC pricing, announcement
NAT Gateway	**$0.045/hour + $0.045/GB** processed (us-east-1), **not free**	VPC pricing
ALB	**$0.0225/hour + $0.008 per LCU-hour** (us-east-1). Free tier: **750 h/month** shared between Classic and Application LBs + **15 LCUs**	ELB pricing
EKS	**$0.10 per cluster per hour**, not free	EKS pricing
ECR	**500 MB/month** private storage for one year (free tier), 50 GB always free for public repos	ECR pricing
SSM Parameter Store	Standard parameters: **no additional charge** (standard throughput)	SSM pricing
Secrets Manager	**$0.40/secret/month + $0.05 per 10,000 API calls**. No separate trial; credits apply	Secrets Manager pricing
CloudWatch	**10** custom/detailed metrics, **10** alarm metrics, **3** custom dashboards, **5 GB** logs (ingestion + archive + Logs Insights scanned), 1M API requests	CloudWatch pricing
S3, EBS	Check the current always-free / free-plan amounts on each pricing page; they're billed per GB-month beyond that	S3 pricing, EBS pricing

4.2 GCP

Source: Free Google Cloud features and trial offer.

Free Trial:

Item	What you get
Credit	**$300 Welcome credit, valid for 90 days**
Eligibility	Never a paying user of Google Cloud, Google Maps Platform or Firebase, and never signed up for the Free Trial before
When it ends	Resources are **stopped**, data in e.g. Compute Engine is **marked for deletion**, and you lose access. You have a **30-day grace period** to upgrade and maybe recover; after that, resources are **permanently deleted**. **No automatic charging**: you must upgrade manually
Not allowed during the trial	GPUs, Windows Server VMs, Marketplace, **quota increases**, crypto mining, VMware Engine, using the credit for the Gemini API / generative AI partner models

Always Free (also after the trial):

Service	Always Free allowance
Compute Engine	**1 non-preemptible e2-micro** VM/month in **us-west1, us-central1 or us-east1**; **30 GB-months standard persistent disk**; **1 GB** egress from North America per month
Cloud Storage	**5 GB-months regional storage** (US regions only: us-east1, us-west1, us-central1); **5,000 Class A** and **50,000 Class B** operations; **100 GB** egress from North America per month
GKE	**One free Autopilot or zonal Standard cluster per month**. The credit covers the **cluster management fee only**; nodes and pods are still charged
Secret Manager	**6 active secret versions** and **10,000 access operations** per month
Artifact Registry	**0.5 GB** storage per month
Cloud Logging	First **50 GiB** of logs per project per month
Cloud Monitoring	First **1 million** time series returned by API read calls per billing account
Cloud Build	**2,500 build-minutes/month** (e2-standard-2)
Cloud Run	**2 million requests**, **360,000 GB-seconds** memory, **180,000 vCPU-seconds** per month

Other prices to know:

- **External IPv4 on a VM: $0.005 per hour** (VPC network pricing). Check that page for any free hours.

- **Cloud NAT** and **load balancer forwarding rules** are charged hourly (Cloud NAT pricing, network pricing). Check the current numbers on those pages.

---

5. Cost traps and how to avoid them

Trap	Why it costs	What to do
NAT gateway / Cloud NAT	Hourly fee plus per-GB processing, even when idle (AWS: $0.045/h + $0.045/GB)	Don't create one. Use a public VM with a tight SG/firewall, or create NAT only for the demo and destroy it
Public IPv4 addresses	AWS and GCP both charge per hour per IP, **including idle Elastic IPs**	One public IP per project; release unused Elastic IPs / static IPs
Load balancers	Charged per hour as long as they exist, with no traffic needed	Use k3s ingress daily; create the LB only for the demo, then `terraform destroy` it
Managed Kubernetes	EKS $0.10/h per cluster; GKE nodes cost money	k3s on VMs
Managed databases	Not allowed in this project, and expensive	Self-hosted DB
Forgotten disks and snapshots	Billed per GB-month after the VM is gone	`terraform destroy`; check *EBS → Volumes / Snapshots* or *Compute Engine → Disks / Snapshots*
Log volume	CloudWatch free tier is 5 GB, Cloud Logging 50 GiB/project; debug logs in a loop fill that fast	`LOG_LEVEL=INFO`, short retention (e.g. 7 days), no logging of request bodies
Data egress	Traffic leaving the cloud is billed beyond the free amount	Don't serve large files publicly; keep backups in the same region
Leftover clusters / VMs in other regions	You forget them because the console shows one region at a time	Use one region; check *Billing → by region* or *Cost Explorer*
Instance types outside the free tier	Larger types burn credits quickly	Stick to the types in §4; read the price before `apply`
Secrets Manager with many secrets	$0.40 per secret per month each	Few secrets, or Parameter Store standard (AWS) / within 6 versions (GCP)
Terraform state or `.env` in git	Leaked keys get abused within minutes, and the bill is yours	`.gitignore` state and `.env`; gitleaks in CI; rotate any key that leaked

---

6. Daily routine (5 minutes)

When you start working:

1. Open **Billing / Cost Explorer** (AWS) or **Billing** → **Reports** (GCP). Check yesterday's cost and the credit balance.
2. Learner Lab: **Start Lab** and copy fresh credentials from *AWS Details*.

When you stop working:

1. **Scale to zero or stop:** stop the VMs, or `kubectl scale deploy --all --replicas=0` if the VMs must keep running.
2. Destroy anything that bills by the hour and isn't needed until next time: LB, NAT, managed cluster.
3. **After every demo or test run:** `terraform destroy` (or `terraform destroy -target=...` for the expensive parts). A full `destroy` and then `apply` from scratch is also proof that your IaC works.
4. Once a week, look for leftovers: unattached disks, old snapshots, unused IPs, empty buckets, images in the registry.

---

7. If your credits run out

1. **Tell the instructor immediately**, before the deadline rather than after.
2. **Switch to AWS Academy Learner Lab** (AWS track) and re-deploy with your Terraform. That's why everything must be in code.
3. **Record your demo before you tear things down.** A 3–5 minute video showing the running system (app, Grafana, logs, CI run, failover drill) is part of the submission anyway.
4. **Local cluster as a last resort:** the **orchestration** part only may be demonstrated on a local **kind / k3d** cluster, **with the point cap given in the RUBRIC**. Cloud networking, IAM/roles, secret manager and IaC must still be shown on a real cloud, at least once, recorded.

---

8. Checklist before the defense

□ Budget and alerts exist and you can show them (screenshot in the report)
□ MFA on root / account owner
□ Everything you create is in one region and visible in Terraform
□ `terraform apply` from scratch works (tested this week)
□ Demo video recorded (in case the live demo fails or credits run out)
□ No NAT, LB or extra public IPs left running when you're not demoing
□ No secrets in git (`gitleaks` passes), no state file committed
□ Cost estimate and actual spend (screenshot) in the report
□ Plan for after the defense: `terraform destroy` , delete leftover disks/snapshots/images, and (for your own account) decide whether to close it or keep it on the free plan

---

Sources (checked 2026-11-06)

- AWS Free Tier: https://aws.amazon.com/free/, FAQs: https://aws.amazon.com/free/free-tier-faqs/
- EC2 free tier usage and eligible types: https://docs.aws.amazon.com/AWSEC2/latest/UserGuide/ec2-free-tier-usage.html
- VPC pricing (NAT, public IPv4): https://aws.amazon.com/vpc/pricing/; public IPv4 free tier: https://aws.amazon.com/about-aws/whats-new/2024/02/aws-free-tier-750-hours-free-public-ipv4-addresses/
- ELB pricing: https://aws.amazon.com/elasticloadbalancing/pricing/
- EKS pricing: https://aws.amazon.com/eks/pricing/
- ECR pricing: https://aws.amazon.com/ecr/pricing/
- Systems Manager pricing: https://aws.amazon.com/systems-manager/pricing/
- Secrets Manager pricing: https://aws.amazon.com/secrets-manager/pricing/
- CloudWatch pricing: https://aws.amazon.com/cloudwatch/pricing/
- Google Cloud free features and trial: https://docs.cloud.google.com/free/docs/free-cloud-features
- Google Cloud network pricing: https://cloud.google.com/vpc/network-pricing; Cloud NAT pricing: https://cloud.google.com/nat/pricing
- Google Cloud payment methods: https://docs.cloud.google.com/billing/docs/how-to/payment-methods